

The Black Cat

Edgar Allan Poe · 1843

First published: Saturday Evening Post, Aug 1843

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

Cover: Claude Monet, The Magpie (1868–1869). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).

Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Works_of_the_Late_Edgar_Allan_Poe_(1850)/Volume_1/The_Black_Cat (revision 14833565), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 10–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Black Cat suggest about guilt and perversity?
- What does The Black Cat suggest about alcohol and violence?
- What does The Black Cat suggest about confession?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	The Black Cat	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*guilt and perversity* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: The Black Cat

Focus: self-destruction and the urge to do wrong

Content note (animal cruelty, murder of a wife, alcohol abuse): Sensitive content: Animal cruelty, murder of a wife, alcohol abuse. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes animal cruelty, murder of a wife, alcohol abuse.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

On the night before his execution, the narrator recounts how drink turned him from a gentle animal-lover into a violent man. He blinds and then hangs his cat Pluto; his house burns, leaving the image of a cat on a wall. A second, similar cat appears, with a white patch that slowly takes the shape of a gallows. Trying to kill it, he murders his wife with an axe and walls her body up in the cellar. When police search, he raps on the wall, and the cat's howl reveals the corpse; he had walled the cat in with her.

Background: Published in 1843 in the Saturday Evening Post, it appeared amid the temperance movement, which blamed alcohol for domestic violence.

Significance: Poe's idea of 'perverseness', the urge to do wrong because it is wrong, anticipates later psychology.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: Why do people sometimes do things they know are wrong? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes animal cruelty, murder of a wife, alcohol abuse.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are deliberated, endeared, allayed, playmate, hangman. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "Again, I deliberated about casting it in the well in the yard—about packing it in a box, as if merchandize, with the usual arrangements, and so getting a porter to take it from the house." In this sentence it means: thought carefully about. Word histories: "deliberated": From Latin deliberare "to weigh well," from de- (intensive) + librare "to balance," from libra "scales." (Not from liber "free.") For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of The Black Cat would have known. Published in 1843 in the Saturday Evening Post, it appeared amid the temperance movement, which blamed alcohol for domestic violence. Why does this story matter? Poe's idea of 'perverseness', the urge to do wrong because it is wrong, anticipates later psychology. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for point of view.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "I married early, and was happy to find in my wife a disposition not uncongenial with my own." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to self-destruction and the urge to do wrong? I circle "procuring", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find point of view, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for point of view.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of point of view. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *I married early, and was happy to find in my wife a disposition not uncongenial with my own. Observing my partiality for domestic pets, she lost no opportunity of procuring those of the most agreeable kind. We had birds, gold-fish, a fine dog, rabbits, a small monkey, and a cat.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Point of view, Symbolism, Irony: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Black Cat develops the idea of self-destruction and the urge to do wrong. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to guilt and perversity? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about self-destruction and the urge to do wrong, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how point of view shapes self-destruction and the urge to do wrong. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
deliberated (verb)	thought carefully about	*Again, I deliberated about casting it in the well in the yard—about packing it in a box, as if merchandize, with the usual arrangements, and so getting a porter to take it from the house.*	“deliberated”: From Latin deliberare "to weigh well," from de- (intensive) + librare "to balance," from libra "scales." (Not from liber "free.") (Online Etymology Dictionary, https://www.etymonline.com/word/deliberate)
endeared (verb)	made loved or liked	*This circumstance, however, only endeared it to my wife, who, as I have already said, possessed, in a high degree, that humanity of feeling which had once been my distinguishing trait, and the source of many of my simplest and purest pleasures.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
allayed (verb)	lessen the intensity of or calm	*"Gentlemen," I said at last, as the party ascended the steps, "I delight to have allayed your suspicions.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
playmate (noun)	a companion at play	*Pluto—this was the cat's name—was my favorite pet and playmate.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
hangman (noun)	an executioner who hangs the condemned person	*Upon its head, with red extended mouth and solitary eye of fire, sat the hideous beast whose craft had seduced me into murder, and whose informing voice had consigned me to the hangman.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
nurtured (verb)	help develop, help grow	*My original soul seemed, at once, to take its flight from my body; and a more than fiendish malevolence, gin-*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

		nurtured, thrilled every fibre of my frame.	
consigned (verb)	commit forever; commit irrevocably	*Upon its head, with red extended mouth and solitary eye of fire, sat the hideous beast whose craft had seduced me into murder, and whose informing voice had consigned me to the hangman.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
procuring (verb)	get by special effort	*Observing my partiality for domestic pets, she lost no opportunity of procuring those of the most agreeable kind.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
detailed (verb)	explained point by point	*Although I thus readily accounted to my reason, if not altogether to my conscience, for the startling fact just detailed, it did not the less fail to make a deep impression upon my fancy.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
abusing (verb)	treat badly	*I avoided the creature; a certain sense of shame, and the remembrance of my former deed of cruelty, preventing me from physically abusing it.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Why do people sometimes do things they know are wrong?
2. Where does point of view appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with guilt and perversity?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What is the name of the narrator's first cat? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Pluto
2. What does the narrator blame for his change in temper? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Alcohol, 'the Fiend Intemperance'
3. What appears on the wall after the fire? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: The image of a gigantic cat with a rope around its neck

4. What shape does the white patch on the second cat take? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A gallows
5. What exposes the murder? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: The cat's cry from behind the wall
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Black Cat" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: On the night before his execution, the narrator recounts how drink turned him from a gentle animal-lover into a violent man. He blinds and then hangs his cat Pluto; his house burns, leaving the image of a cat on a wall. A second, similar cat appears, with a white patch that slowly takes the shape of a gallows. Trying to kill it, he murders his wife with an axe and walls her body up in the cellar…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Black Cat"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Black Cat" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "Again, I deliberated about casting it in the well in the yard—about packing it in a box, as if merchandize, with the usual arrangements, and so getting a porter to take it from the house." What does "deliberated" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: deliberated: thought carefully about.
10. Reread: "This circumstance, however, only endeared it to my wife, who, as I have already said, possessed, in a high degree, that humanity of feeling which had once been my distinguishing trait, and the source of many of my…" What does "endeared" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: endeared: made loved or liked.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "The Black Cat" suggest about self-destruction and the urge to do wrong? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: Poe's idea of 'perverseness', the urge to do wrong because it is wrong, anticipates later psychology.
2. Find one example of point of view in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know.
3. How does the symbolism in this story shape what we understand about self-destruction and the urge to do wrong? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
4. In the passage that begins "I married early, and was happy to find in my wife a disposition not uncongenial with my own.", why might Poe have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in "The Black Cat", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: On the night before his execution, the narrator recounts how drink turned him from a gentle animal-lover into a violent man. He blinds and then hangs his cat Pluto; his house burns, leaving the image of a cat on a wall. A second, similar cat appears, with a white patch that slowly takes the shape…

6. As the opening story, what does “The Black Cat” set up that the rest of The Black Cat will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Why do people sometimes do things they know are wrong?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does irony appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with guilt and perversity? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
10. Background: Published in 1843 in the Saturday Evening Post, it appeared amid the temperance movement, which blamed alcohol for domestic violence. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “Poe's idea of 'perverseness', the urge to do wrong because it is wrong, anticipates later psychology.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Black Cat” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about self-destruction and the urge to do wrong? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about “The Black Cat”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to alcohol and violence: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Poe need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the point of view in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how “The Black Cat” treats self-destruction and the urge to do wrong with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Black Cat see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve guilt and perversity? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about self-destruction and the urge to do wrong? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Edgar Allan Poe about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Point of view:** look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true

Chapter quiz

1. What is the name of the narrator's first cat?
   A. Shadow
   B. Midnight
   C. Lucifer
   D. Pluto
2. What does the narrator blame for his change in temper?
   A. Alcohol, 'the Fiend Intemperance'
   B. The cat
   C. His job
   D. His wife
3. What appears on the wall after the fire?
   A. His initials
   B. A door
   C. The image of a gigantic cat with a rope around its neck
   D. A painted cross
4. What shape does the white patch on the second cat take?
   A. A gallows
   B. A heart
   C. A key
   D. A star
5. What exposes the murder?
   A. A letter
   B. The cat's cry from behind the wall
   C. Blood on the floor
   D. A neighbor's testimony

6. In the line “Again, I deliberated about casting it in the well in the yard—about packing it in a box, as if merchandize, with the usual arrangements, and so getting a porter to take it from the house.”, what does “deliberated” most nearly mean?
   A. thought carefully about
   B. lessen the intensity of or calm
   C. a companion at play
   D. made loved or liked
7. In the line “This circumstance, however, only endeared it to my wife, who, as I have already said, possessed, in a high degree, that humanity of feeling which had once been my distinguishing trait, and the source of many of my simplest and purest pleasures.”, what does “endeared” most nearly mean?
   A. lessen the intensity of or calm
   B. thought carefully about
   C. a companion at play
   D. made loved or liked

Answer key: 1. D (Pluto); 2. A (Alcohol, 'the Fiend Intemperance'); 3. C (The image of a gigantic cat with a rope around its neck); 4. A (A gallows); 5. B (The cat's cry from behind the wall); 6. A (thought carefully about); 7. D (made loved or liked)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.6, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.1, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Black Cat,” how does Poe show self-destruction and the urge to do wrong? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the point of view you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In The Black Cat, how does Poe develop the idea of self-destruction and the urge to do wrong? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the point of view in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Black Cat develops the idea of self-destruction and the urge to do wrong. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Black Cat (where it begins, turns and ends) and its point of view shape the reader's understanding of self-destruction and the urge to do wrong. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Black Cat suggests about self-destruction and the urge to do wrong. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for

each (including the story's point of view and symbolism), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Edgar Allan Poe uses point of view in The Black Cat to complicate the reader's understanding of self-destruction and the urge to do wrong. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Black Cat within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of self-destruction and the urge to do wrong responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Black Cat alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of self-destruction and the urge to do wrong follows or bends those conventions, using the point of view as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Black Cat and its treatment of self-destruction and the urge to do wrong. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's point of view and symbolism, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Black Cat as evidence for a larger claim about self-destruction and the urge to do wrong in The Black Cat. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Black Cat as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of self-destruction and the urge to do wrong. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Black Cat.

SAT-style questions

1. *"Gentlemen," I said at last, as the party ascended the steps, "I delight to have allayed your suspicions.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “allayed” most nearly mean?

   A. lessen the intensity of or calm

   B. treat badly

   C. get by special effort

   D. explained point by point

2. *I married early, and was happy to find in my wife a disposition not uncongenial with my own. Observing my partiality for domestic pets, she lost no opportunity of procuring those of the most agreeable kind. We had birds, gold-fish, a fine dog, rabbits, a small monkey, and a cat.*

Which choice best states a central concern of "The Black Cat"?

A. Science that poisons love

B. Self-destruction and the urge to do wrong

C. A girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval

D. The loss of faith in human goodness

SAT key: 1. A (lessen the intensity of or calm); 2. B (Self-destruction and the urge to do wrong)

Whole-book test

The Black Cat: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. What is the name of the narrator's first cat?
   A. Shadow
   B. Midnight
   C. Lucifer
   D. Pluto
2. What does the narrator blame for his change in temper?
   A. Alcohol, 'the Fiend Intemperance'
   B. The cat
   C. His job
   D. His wife
3. What appears on the wall after the fire?
   A. His initials
   B. A door
   C. The image of a gigantic cat with a rope around its neck
   D. A painted cross
4. What shape does the white patch on the second cat take?
   A. A gallows
   B. A heart
   C. A key
   D. A star
5. What exposes the murder?
   A. A letter
   B. The cat's cry from behind the wall
   C. Blood on the floor
   D. A neighbor's testimony
6. In the line “Again, I deliberated about casting it in the well in the yard—about packing it in a box, as if merchandize, with the usual arrangements, and so getting a porter to take it from the house.”, what does “deliberated” most nearly mean?
   A. thought carefully about
   B. lessen the intensity of or calm
   C. a companion at play
   D. made loved or liked

7. In the line “This circumstance, however, only endeared it to my wife, who, as I have already said, possessed, in a high degree, that humanity of feeling which had once been my distinguishing trait, and the source of many of my simplest and purest pleasures.”, what does “endeared” most nearly mean?
   A. lessen the intensity of or calm
   B. thought carefully about
   C. a companion at play
   D. made loved or liked
8. As used in the story (“Again, I deliberated about casting it in the well in the yard—about packing it in a box, as if merchandize, with the usual arrangements, and”), what does “deliberated” mean?
   A. thought carefully about
   B. an executioner who hangs the condemned person
   C. get by special effort
   D. made loved or liked
9. As used in the story (“This circumstance, however, only endeared it to my wife, who, as I have already said, possessed, in a high degree, that humanity of feeling ”), what does “endeared” mean?
   A. help develop, help grow
   B. made loved or liked
   C. explained point by point
   D. lessen the intensity of or calm
10. As used in the story (“"Gentlemen," I said at last, as the party ascended the steps, "I delight to have allayed your suspicions.”), what does “allayed” mean?
   A. commit forever; commit irrevocably
   B. treat badly
   C. lessen the intensity of or calm
   D. a companion at play
11. As used in the story (“Pluto—this was the cat's name—was my favorite pet and playmate.”), what does “playmate” mean?
   A. get by special effort
   B. thought carefully about
   C. an executioner who hangs the condemned person
   D. a companion at play
12. As used in the story (“Upon its head, with red extended mouth and solitary eye of fire, sat the hideous beast whose craft had seduced me into murder, and whose inf”), what does “hangman” mean?
   A. an executioner who hangs the condemned person
   B. explained point by point
   C. made loved or liked
   D. help develop, help grow

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how guilt and perversity develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how alcohol and violence develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how confession develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (guilt and perversity, alcohol and violence, confession) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. D (Pluto); 2. A (Alcohol, 'the Fiend Intemperance'); 3. C (The image of a gigantic cat with a rope around its neck); 4. A (A gallows); 5. B (The cat's cry from behind the wall); 6. A (thought carefully about); 7. D (made loved or liked); 8. A (thought carefully about); 9. B (made loved or liked); 10. C (lessen the intensity of or calm); 11. D (a companion at play); 12. A (an executioner who hangs the condemned person)

Essay assignments

Essay: Guilt and perversity

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Black Cat teaches about guilt and perversity. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops guilt and perversity in The Black Cat. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops guilt and perversity across The Black Cat. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Black Cat (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of guilt and perversity. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of guilt and perversity in The Black Cat. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Black Cat (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of guilt and perversity, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Black Cat's treatment of guilt and perversity in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on guilt and perversity in The Black Cat that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on guilt and perversity in The Black Cat. Name your critical method,

apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about guilt and perversity in The Black Cat, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on guilt and perversity in The Black Cat, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Alcohol and violence

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Black Cat teaches about alcohol and violence. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops alcohol and violence in The Black Cat. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops alcohol and violence across The Black Cat. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Black Cat (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of alcohol and violence. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of alcohol and violence in The Black Cat. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Black Cat (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of alcohol and violence, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Black Cat's treatment of alcohol and violence in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on alcohol and violence in The Black Cat that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on alcohol and violence in The Black Cat. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about alcohol and violence in The Black Cat, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on alcohol and violence in The Black Cat, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Confession

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Black Cat teaches about confession. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops confession in The Black Cat. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops confession across The Black Cat. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Black Cat (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of confession. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of confession in The Black Cat. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Black Cat (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of confession, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Black Cat's treatment of confession in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on confession in The Black Cat that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on confession in The Black Cat. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about confession in The Black Cat, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on confession in The Black Cat, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary, 2026-10-20); other words are student look-ups. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.